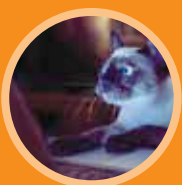


THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In Geek-key, learn about what you could do in situations where you don't have a key. Then in Infoporn, take a look at how various different movies are connected to each other. After that, check out the fastest supercomputers in the world in 1000-Words.



Cats controlling spacecraft

After an ESA engineer's cat photobombed a WFH conference call, there was a discussion on whether cats can accidentally commandeer spacecraft. Unfortunately, turns out that it is not possible for household pets to gain control of spacecraft. <https://dgit.in/catcrft>

WHAT'S NEW

The origin story of the N95 respirator

A surgical mask is there for a very particular reason. It is actually to protect the patient and not the doctor. The mask prevents microbes riding on water borne droplets to enter the body of the patient and infecting them. A respirator on the other hand, is almost airtight, and sits closely on the face, forcing respiration through the fabric. It was invented in China by a young doctor who guessed that the plague that was raging in 1910 in Manchuria spread through the air, and not through animals. He padded up existing surgical masks with cotton and gauze, forcing the wearers to breathe through the cotton. A racist French physician dismissed the mask, and promptly died after getting afflicted by



the plague. The Chinese doctor, Lien-teh Wu, chosen by the imperial court went on to successfully

tackle the pandemic. The N95 respirator developed at 3M is based on Wu's design. It was originally made for industrial workers. Those working with asbestos or silicon would get respiratory illnesses because of the dust. The fabric used in the 3M mask looks like a bunch of random sticks under a microscope, and this fabric is good at trapping the dust. It is also good at trapping viruses and other small particles.

The virus has changed our surfing habits

Most people are spending more time online because everything is shut down, and most people are working and playing by using their screens. The outbreak has seen some drastic shifts in the ways people are using their devices. The usage of Facebook, YouTube and Netflix all saw huge boosts, but at the same time, people were using these apps and services more from their laptops or desktops, with a



reduction being seen in terms of smartphone usage. This has reversed a shift towards smartphones that has been ongoing for years. Now, more users are turning away from their phones. The outbreak

also gave a big boost to video chatting apps, especially the ones that were previously not used so much, including Zoom, Duo and Houseparty, which just went to the top of social media app listings on stores. While sporting sites have seen major falls in traffic as most events are cancelled (the Belarusian Premier League is continuing though), videogaming sites are seeing big boosts. <https://dgit.in/virusurfing>



Ads for the misinformed

While the Facebook CEO put out a post detailing the steps taken by the company to curtail the spread of misinformation regarding the virus, those buying ads on the platform can target those that are already misinformed, or people interested in pseudoscience. <https://dgit.in/fbads2>



Escaping a submarine

Imagine being stuck in a dysfunctional submarine on the sea floor with the task of having to escape. While it seems like an impossible thing to accomplish, there are some people who have actually managed to do it, but only with the help of a good understanding of physics. <https://dgit.in/subxcape>



End of two spacers

While Microsoft Office has offered a toggle to mark double spaces as an error for years, apparently it has been turned on by default for some users, which marks the end of an era, as an old method of spacing from the time of typewriters finally becomes irrelevant. <https://dgit.in/dblspc>